Introduction

Indians are a resilient people. Perhaps, all people are. But there is a stoicism about Indians, especially in the face of adversity, that foreign observers have traditionally dismissed as fatalism. In truth, there is nothing fatalistic about our tremendous capacity to accept life as it comes and to get on with it, armed with the belief that our misfortunes and those who visited them on us, will pass on … in time.

We are also an innovative race, with an incredible ability for 'jugaad' when faced with odds that would be daunting for others.

In recent times, there has been no better demonstration of this resilience and tremendous capacity for innovation than the response to and recovery from the dramatic demonetization announced by the Prime Minister, Narendra Modi, on 8 November 2016.

I write this book both as a banker and as a deeply committed and active citizen of India, for I believe the demonetization story must be told.

Ours was an armed forces family. My father was transferred to different parts of the country during our childhood. During our many transfers we were exposed to the diversity of India and grew up with people of all castes and religions. It was an India in which we were all striving to make something of our lives, in a country that was emerging from the scars of Partition.